



LIGHTS OUT: Left leaders are out on a mission to explain their actions

has meant many things to many people. OB vans that stalled traffic at Delhi's Gole Market, where the CPI(M) office is headquartered, have moved on to the next big thing. Karat, the steel-in-the-spine stalwart, has now been reduced to Mayawati's bhai—that is how the BSP chief addressed him at their last media briefing, recalling how BJP leader Lalji Tandon had received a similar honorific only to be described as Lalchi (greedy) Tandon soon enough by the changeable politician.

If the CPI(M) is unsure about the way Mayawati will behave, fearing she could end up with the BJP, they have less reason to trust their once-and-future-enemy's other former allies as well—the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), Janata Dal (Secular) and Asom Gana Parishad. In Andhra Pradesh, the CPI(M) and CPI are yet to reach an agreement over supporting the TDP in the state. A major faction of leaders in the CPI is against teaming up with the TDP and is for continuing ties with the Congress in the state. Well known actor Chiranjeevi, who is planning his entry into electoral politics, is seen as a potential Left ally.

The Left parties, in turn, are yet to decide on withdrawing the support of their legislators to the M. Karunanidhi Government in Tamil Nadu after DMK MPs voted in favour of the UPA Government. The central leadership, considering its long-standing friendship with Karunanidhi, is weighing various options.

The CPI(M) will also try to turn the popular sympathy for Somnath Chatterjee into a symbol of its strict disciplinarian ways to offset its political isolation and to show that its leadership is in control of the party apparatus—if not of events in Parliament. The CPI(M) top leadership will also travel to various zonal party units to explain the decision. In the process, it will reassure everyone that its Leninist organisational structure is intact. The addition to their frequent flier miles won't hurt. Some compensation at least for the hours lost lambasting the Government on nationwide television screens. ■

ment at the Centre. The party will also use the Hiroshima-Nagasaki Day on August 6 to protest against the deal.

In Kerala, the CPI(M) has already started its campaign in the Muslim-dominated areas, deploying star campaigner and Manjeri MP T.K. Hamza. The CPI is pitting youth leader Suneer against Indian Union Muslim League leader and Minister of State for External Affairs F. Ahamed, who is expected to seek re-election from Ponnani constituency. On its part, the UPA Government is moving ahead with its plans to push through economic reforms, including disinvestment of navratnas, once blocked by the Left.

In the past 45 months, the Left had played its role of the enemy within with flair. Of the 300 statements issued by the CPI(M) during its unhappy marriage to the UPA, most of them were peppered with words like "opposing", "criticising" and "advising", meant for the "wayward policies of the Manmohan Singh Government". Much ink was spilled to demonstrate its pathological distaste for the nuclear deal, while over 50 statements were issued to warn the nation of its foreign policy complications.

The nuclear deal fallout

BRINDA KARAT, CPI(M)
AGONISED AUNT

Is now more concerned about farmers and blast victims in Gujarat

A.B. BARDHAN, CPI
SOUND BYTE SOLDIER

Fond of scolding TV anchors, he's out of studios for a party meeting in Amritsar

